A Strategist's Basic Bookshelf

An Annotated Reading List

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MAY 05, 2025

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To learn strategy, you should read some basic source books. This list presented here mixes military, political, and business strategy sources. Some are easy and inviting, while others demand more concentrated attention to unfamiliar background events archaic narrative styles.

I include only a few books on business strategy. When reading about business strat

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on “leadership”—these are almost all about perfecting oneself to project a compelli vision. They are not about actually leading anyone.

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Classic Military and Political Strategy

Sun Tzu, *The Art of War* (5th century BC). Considered one of the most impactful strategy books ever written, this early Chinese work is believed to have been autho by General Sun Tzu during the Eastern Zhou dynasty. It contains 13 chapters that present insights on leadership, deception, terrain, and the art of achieving victory without direct confrontation. *The Art of War* shaped the course of East Asian milita practices for centuries and has influenced Western military thought and other field Its teachings (e.g., “subdue the enemy without fighting”) are still part of the curricu in military academies and business schools, with many modern executives applying Sun Tzu’s principles as frameworks for competitive strategy and negotiation.

Thucydides, *History of the Peloponnesian War* (5th century BC). Thucydides was an exiled Athenian general. His eyewitness account details the conflict between Athen and Sparta (431–404 BC). It illustrates power dynamics, coalition politics, and the interplay between war and humanity. If nothing else, read Pericles' funeral oration (Ch. VI) and the description of the aftermath of the debacle in Sicily (Ch. XXIV). Thucydides provides a cautionary tale about employing war as a policy tool, with insights into the pitfalls of excess and the “Thucydides Trap” involving rising and ruling powers. His theory of motives—“fear, honor, interest”—and the renowned *Melian Dialogue* remain influential in strategy and international relations education

Kautilya (**also known as Chanakya**), *The Arthashastra* (circa 3rd century BC). Often

referred to as "the Indian Machiavelli," Kautilya was a prominent mentor who guid Chandragupta Maurya in establishing an empire. The *Arthashastra* covers statecraft foreign relations, economics, and warfare. It promotes a pragmatic and often ruthle approach to governance, encompassing tactics such as espionage, diplomacy, and military strategies. After being lost for centuries, it was rediscovered in 1905 and contains many concepts that resonate in Machiavelli's *The Prince*.

Niccolò Machiavelli, *The Prince* (1513). Written as a concise guide for rulers on gaining and maintaining power, it was developed by a Florentine diplomat during Italy's volatile city-state politics. The reader is struck by his brutal honesty. Paying homage to skill, he also recognizes that it only achieves when the situation is ripe. Thus, in explaining how Cyrus conquered Persia, he says, "It was necessary that Cy should find the Persians discontented with the government of the Medes, and the Medes soft and effeminate through their long peace." Recognized as a foundational text in modern political strategy and realist philosophy, the term "Machiavellian" h become a descriptor for pragmatic statecraft. Few works in political philosophy are significant to grand strategy and diplomacy.

Miyamoto Musashi, *The Book of Five Rings* (1645). A reflective piece written by the legendary samurai in his later years, focusing on sword fighting and strategy. Whil is mainly centered on individual combat, the five chapters—"Earth," "Water," "Fire "Wind," and "Void"—encapsulate principles that apply to warfare and competition general. Musashi promotes the idea of adaptability and an "indirect" method to unsettle adversaries. Over time, *Five Rings* has become a strategy classic, studied by individuals in business, sports, and various competitive domains. Musashi's belief t the warrior's path aligns with the strategist's has echoed well beyond 17th-century Japan.

Carl von Clausewitz, *On War* (1832). A comprehensive analysis of warfare from the perspective of a Prussian general involved in the Napoleonic Wars. Posthumously published by his wife, *On War* explores ambiguity and uncertainty and emphasizes

importance of political objectives. Clausewitz stated that "war is a mere continuati of policy by other means," encapsulating his argument that military strategy serves political purposes. *On War* remains an influential work on military strategy that is relevant and thought-provoking for contemporary strategic discourse. Pay particula attention to his chapter on *surprise*: "It lies more or less at the foundation of all undertakings, for without it the preponderance at the decisive point is not properly conceivable."

Antoine-Henri Jomini, *Summary of the Art of War* (1838). As a contemporary of Clausewitz, Baron de Jomini was a Swiss military officer who served Napoleon. His *of War* outlines Napoleonic battlefield strategies through prescriptive formulas (suc as lines of operation and points of decision) and promotes the idea of warfare as a systematic science. Jomini's contributions significantly influenced military practice in the 19th century. Few authors impacted military operations before 1870 as profoundly as Jomini, whose theories were instrumental for many generals during t U.S. Civil War. He supported the idea of concentrated force targeting enemy weaknesses and using interior lines—principles that became foundational in milita academies. However, after 1870, Clausewitz's theories eclipsed Jomini's work, and h writings are less commonly studied today. Nonetheless, reading Jomini provides insight into strategy teaching in the 1800s and contrasts with Clausewitz's perspectives.

Alfred Thayer Mahan, *The Influence of Sea Power upon History, 1660–1783* (1890). T seminal work by U.S. Navy Captain A.T. Mahan outlines how maritime dominance shaped the destinies of major powers, particularly Britain's rise. Mahan argues that state's strength and prosperity hinge on its naval and commercial capabilities. This book had a profound impact, regarded by scholars as the most significant single volume on maritime strategy, embraced by all major navies. It triggered the naval a race leading to World War I. The Mahanian principles—developing battleship fleet capturing coaling stations, and controlling critical chokepoints—shaped naval strategies for the British Empire, Imperial Germany, the United States, and Japan.

Additionally, the concept of Sea Power contributed to the evolution of U.S. strategi thinking as America emerged as a great power, especially the relationship between economic power and global military policy. Mahan's analysis of England's landed aristocracy is fascinating: "Such a class, whatever its defects otherwise, readily take up and carries on a sound political tradition, is naturally proud of its country's glor and comparatively insensible to the sufferings of the community by which that glor maintained. It readily lays on the pecuniary burden necessary for preparation and f endurance of war. Being as a body rich, it feels those burdens less. Not being commercial, the sources of its own wealth are not so immediately endangered, and does not share that political timidity which characterizes those whose property is exposed and business threatened—the proverbial timidity of capital."

B.H. Liddell Hart, *Strategy: The Indirect Approach* (1954). Liddell Hart advocates fo the "indirect approach," which focuses on targeting the enemy's vulnerabilities and disrupting their balance rather than engaging in direct confrontation. Criticizing t costly frontal assaults of World War I, he played a significant role in shaping armor warfare in the interwar period. This work is regarded as a foundational text in milit theory, often mentioned alongside the works of Sun Tzu and Clausewitz. Liddell H emphasizes the importance of flexibility, surprise, and the psychological impact on opponents. While some of his assertions, such as the indirect influence on the Gern Blitzkrieg, may be debated, his succinct prose and broad range of examples solidify this book's status as a significant contribution to modern strategy.

Thomas C. Schelling. *The Strategy of Conflict* (1960). This work integrates game-theoretic analysis with military and political strategy. Schelling, an American economist and planner during the Cold War, utilizes game theory to explore theme conflict and cooperation through various examples, including nuclear deterrence, bargaining, and limited war. He discusses ideas such as credible commitments, deterrence based on the threat of mutually assured destruction, focal points, and th rationality of irrational behaviors. Emerging from the Cold War arms race backdro the book offers fresh insights into war prevention. *The Strategy of Conflict* transform

the field of strategic studies, earning him a Nobel Prize in economics for his analys of conflict and cooperation. Its clear explanations (such as the "Chicken" game and negotiation standoffs) remain relevant in diplomatic and business strategies.

Sir Lawrence Freedman, *Strategy: A History* (2013). Lawrence Freedman is Emeritu Professor of War Studies at King's College London. This book explores the evolutio of strategic thought from ancient times up to the 21st century. Freedman examines strategy across various fields, including warfare, politics, social movements, and business, illustrating how this concept has "pervaded every sphere of life." He begi with survival strategies among primates and progresses through the ideas of influential thinkers such as Sun Tzu, Machiavelli, Clausewitz, and Marx, along wit contemporary corporate intellectuals like Peter Drucker. Freedman wonders wheth we can genuinely influence history or are merely subject to chance and circumstanc Although academic, the book remains engaging. It serves as both an intellectual history and a critical exploration of the attainability of strategic goals, making it a good follow-up for those familiar with the primary classical texts.

John Lewis Gaddis, *On Grand Strategy* (2018). This book reflects on statecraft and h to reconcile lofty ambitions with realistic capabilities. The Yale historian, known fc his Cold War expertise, draws on his extensive experience co-teaching a well-regar "Grand Strategy" seminar. He intertwines stories of notable leaders and thinkers— from Herodotus, Thucydides, and Augustus to Queen Elizabeth I, Napoleon, and Lincoln, among others. The narrative uses Isaiah Berlin's fable of the fox and the hedgehog (representing multiple small ideas versus one dominant idea) to illustrate strategic thinking. The book is engaging and rich with stories. For professionals in defense and security, *On Grand Strategy* serves as an introductory guide on conceptualizing and implementing strategy. Gaddis highlights the importance of balancing resources with goals, maintaining adaptability, and learning from histori victories and failures.

Henry Kissinger, *Leadership: Six Studies in World Strategy* (Political, 2022). "Leaders

writes Henry Kissinger, “think and act at the intersection of two axes: the first, between the past and the future; the second, between the abiding values and aspirations of those they lead. They must balance what they know, which is necessa drawn from the past, with what they intuit about the future, which is inherently conjectural and uncertain. This intuitive grasp of direction enables leaders to set objectives and lay down a strategy.” In *Leadership*, Kissinger examines the lives of si prominent leaders: Konrad Adenauer, Charles de Gaulle, Richard Nixon, Anwar Sac Lee Kuan Yew, and Margaret Thatcher. He explores the strategies each exemplified Combining historical insight, public experience, and personal knowledge, Kissinge provides a unique perspective since he engaged in many of the events he recounts. T book benefits from insights and judgments that only Kissinger could offer, conclud with his thoughts on global order and the crucial role of leadership in today’s world

Eliot A. Cohen and John Gooch, *Military Misfortunes: The Anatomy of Failure in W* (Military, 1990). What causes competent armies to fail? Cohen and Gooch provide insights into this question in their analysis of failed military operations. It offers fascinating battlefield stories and innovative explanations for the factors that weak armies. This book has established itself as the definitive examination of the unforeseen disasters that strike presumably capable militaries. The chapter on the early failure of the U.S. in dealing with the German submarine war in 1940 is a mus read. The 2006 edition features a new Afterword reflecting on America's errors in I Somalia, and the War on Terror.

Business and Corporate Strategy (20th–21st Century)

Alfred Sloan, *My Years with General Motors* (1963). This is one of the few business books that can be called a classic. Bill Gates called it out as the best book to read or business. Business Week listed it as number one on its “indispensable” reading bookshelf. The core lessons of the book are in how Sloan created the product policy (strategy) that took GM to the top of the heap in the automobile industry, and his analysis of the distinct roles of corporate management and those of the operating

divisions.

Michael E. Porter. *Competitive Strategy* (1980). Now in its 60th printing, *Competitive Strategy* continues to be a vital resource in business education. Porter's "Five Forces model flipped industrial organization economics to a businessperson's point of viev Thus, corporate profit flowed from positioning in and within an industry characterized by rivalry, buyer power, supplier power, ease of entry, and availability substitutes. A must-read for anyone working in business strategy. His follow-on bo *Competitive Advantage*, is more nuanced and also a must-read.

Clayton M. Christensen, *The Innovator's Dilemma* (1997). This book delves into hov successful companies can crumble under the pressure of "disruptive innovation." Christensen explains that market leaders, focused on current customer needs, often overlook emerging technologies that initially underperform, enabling new entrants seize market leadership. This paradox—the "innovator's dilemma"—awakened a generation of business leaders to the fear of disruption, becoming one of the most impactful business texts ever published.

Chan Kim and Renée Mauborgne, *Blue Ocean Strategy* (2005). A best-selling book aimed at helping companies find "blue oceans"—new, unexplored markets—rather than battling competitors in the saturated "red oceans" of existing industries. The book is essential reading because of its widespread influence—over 4 million copie sold and translations in 47 languages. Its central idea advocates for making competition irrelevant by achieving significant leaps in value, as companies like Cirque du Soleil and Southwest Airlines exemplify. Although some critics argue tha "blue oceans" eventually turn red when others replicate the approach, the principle within the book have firmly established themselves in the business world.

Richard Rumelt, *Good Strategy/Bad Strategy: The Difference and Why it Matters* (20 This book offers a realistic view of what constitutes an effective strategy. A UCLA professor and experienced consultant, Rumelt was frustrated by the buzzwords and vague vision statements frequently presented as "strategy." He delineates the core

components of a solid strategy: a clear assessment of the issue, a guiding policy, an coherent actions. In contrast, he critiques "poor strategy" as mere fluff, idealistic objectives, or a disjointed list of unconnected initiatives. Upon its release, the book "immediately struck a chord" and has since become a highly regarded text on busin strategy.

Biographies — Military and Political

Robin Lane Fox, *Alexander the Great*. Robin Lane Fox's very readable biography examines Alexander's extraordinary campaigns, emphasizing how strategic audacit deliberate risk-taking, and inventive logistical strategies empowered a small Macedonian army to seize tremendous Persian lands.

Adrian Goldsworthy, *Caesar: Life of a Colossus.* Read this to learn about Caesar anc about Roman history. He is quite good on Caesar's military campaigns and Roman generalship. He also highlights how Caesar's talent for coalition-building, navigati Roman political systems, and bold military tactics allowed him to conquer Rome an transform Western civilization.

Jack Weatherford, *Genghis Khan and the Making of the Modern World.* Weatherford revamps the traditional image of Genghis Khan by highlighting the strategic advancements brought by the Mongols, such as meritocracy, information systems, psychological tactics, and swift movements. These approaches enabled an extraordinary conquest and effective governance of the largest contiguous land empire, transforming global trade, diplomacy, and administration.

Andrew Roberts, *Napoleon: A Life*. Roberts provides an in-depth review of Napolec Bonaparte's military and political strategies, uncovering the techniques that shapec his groundbreaking warfare tactics, operational flexibility, logistical control, and capacity to dominate battlefields. The biography highlights the idea of "strategic tempo," illustrating how swift decision-making and continuous offensive initiative revolutionized European warfare.

Ron Chernow, *Grant*. Chernow's work showcases Ulysses S. Grant's strategic geniu maneuver warfare, emphasizing his steadfast and unwavering pursuit of objectives despite challenges. The biography provides insights into Grant's quiet proficiency i operational flexibility, accurate evaluations of enemy weaknesses, and an unyieldin drive for victory.

Jean Edward Smith, *Eisenhower in War and Peace.* This examination of Eisenhower delves into the intricacies of coalition warfare, highlighting Eisenhower's adept coordination of multinational operations, his management of rival personalities, an his logistics-driven, timely, and consensus-oriented strategy. The biography underscores Eisenhower's ability to balance diplomatic priorities with military aim which laid the groundwork for contemporary coalition strategies.

Andrew Roberts, *Churchill: Walking with Destiny.* Roberts vividly illustrates Winsto Churchill's strategic insight and leadership, showcasing his talent for motivating national resilience and resolve. The book emphasizes Churchill's foresight regardin strategic threats, effective communication techniques, psychological grasp of leadership, and key decisions that influenced British and global strategies during WWII.

Doris Kearns Goodwin, *Team of Rivals: The Political Genius of Abraham Lincoln.* Goodwin's biography explores Lincoln's remarkable political skill, demonstrating h his choice to include political adversaries in his cabinet fostered greater unity durir the Civil War. The book highlights Lincoln's psychological insight, political timing adept rivalry management, and the patient quest for strategic consensus, turning political challenges into strategic advantages.

Ezra F. Vogel, *Deng Xiaoping and the Transformation of China*. Vogel provides in-depth analysis of Deng Xiaoping's pragmatic strategy, emphasizing his patience an methodical approach to implementing economic reforms that turned China into a global economic powerhouse. Deng's careful incrementalism, strategic ambiguity—described as "crossing the river by feeling the stones"—and his ability to balance

ideological rigidity with practical flexibility exemplify strategic adaptability.

Anthony Sampson, *Mandela: The Authorized Biography*. Sampson's comprehensive biography showcases Nelson Mandela's remarkable strategic patience, moral leadership, and knack for fostering consensus while navigating intricate political changes. Mandela's clear strategy for pursuing national reconciliation—utilizing symbolic gestures and a long-term vision to oversee significant societal transformation—makes this work essential for understanding strategic leadership i political environments.

Robert Coram, *Boyd: The Fighter Pilot Who Changed the Art of War*. Coram's insightful biography of John Boyd unveils the development and influence of Boyd's groundbreaking OODA (Observe-Orient-Decide-Act) loop framework, which has reshaped contemporary military and business strategies. Boyd's emphasis on agility adaptability, and swift decision-making cycles demonstrates how strategic innovati stems from intellectual discipline and practical experimentation.

William Manchester, *American Caesar: Douglas MacArthur 1880–1964*. Manchester biography explores Douglas MacArthur's strategic bravado, engaging leadership, a the careful equilibrium between military aspirations and geopolitical circumstance offers valuable perspectives on MacArthur's operational boldness, the complexities and advantages of charismatic leadership, and the strategic difficulties tied to civil-military relations during crucial historical events.

Biographies—Business

Ron Chernow, *Titan: The Life of John D. Rockefeller, Sr.* Chernow's comprehensive biography reveals Rockefeller's groundbreaking strategic vision behind Standard O the first major industrial monopoly. Through detailed documentation, Chernow showcases Rockefeller's vertical and horizontal integration innovation, his amazing operational efficiency, disciplined cost management, and clever application of economies of scale. The book illustrates how Rockefeller methodically eliminated

competitors and utilized strategic partnerships and regulatory insights, offering a k example of corporate strategic thinking.

David Nasaw, *Andrew Carnegie*. Nasaw paints a detailed picture of Carnegie's strat brilliance in steel production, illustrating how he transformed manufacturing via vertical integration, from sourcing raw materials to transporting and distributing finished goods. Carnegie's strong focus on cost management, commitment to technological advancements, and strategic investments in efficiency developed last competitive advantages, establishing core strategic concepts regarding efficiency, scale, and market supremacy.

Walter Isaacson, *Steve Jobs*. Isaacson offers unique insights into Jobs' intricate personality and strategic mindset. The biography highlights Jobs' talent for predict consumer needs, intense focus on user experience, relentless drive for product simplification, and unwavering demand for seamless hardware and software integration. Isaacson illustrates Jobs' view of innovation as a strategy.

Brad Stone, *The Everything Store: Jeff Bezos and the Age of Amazon*. This biography explores Bezos' strategic long-term vision, emphasizing his core principle of custor obsession, dedication to operational excellence, and unwavering reinvestment in Amazon's essential infrastructure and logistics. Bezos' strategic choices—including platform diversification, competitive pricing, swift iteration, and significant investments like AWS—demonstrate the effectiveness of persistent long-term strategic execution and illustrate how customer-focused innovation leads to ongoin market disruption.

Sam Walton and John Huey, *Sam Walton: Made In America*. Walton's straightforwa autobiography unveils his key strategic insights, focusing on disciplined cost contr decentralized decision-making, innovation in supply chains, and constant experimentation with store formats. His unwavering drive for everyday low prices, logistical efficiency, and flexible inventory management transformed retail strategy illustrating how operational creativity, frugality, and the ability to scale strategicall

support lasting competitive advantage.

Jack Welch and John A. Byrne, *Jack: Straight from the Gut*. Welch compellingly dep his overhaul of General Electric by emphasizing strategic clarity and strict competi benchmarks. His approaches—such as the "number one or number two" principle, proactive divestment of underachieving segments, and fostering leader empowerme —demonstrate how strategic discipline, effective talent management, cultural alignment, and stringent performance metrics were supposed to result in a nimble, competitive organization. One has to look at what happened after Welch to make a fully informed judgment on his approach.

Lee Iacocca and William Novak, *Iacocca: An Autobiography*. Iacocca's compelling account of Chrysler's brink of failure and rejuvenation presents a strategic framewo for crisis leadership, turnaround management, and innovative marketing strategies He emphasizes the urgent need for clear strategy, decisive action, inventive produc approaches, and effective stakeholder engagement, showing how strategic bravery turn around fortunes in times of severe challenge.

Ashlee Vance, *Elon Musk: Tesla, SpaceX, and the Quest for a Fantastic Future.* Vanc biography offers crucial insights into Musk's strategic vision, analyzing how Musk persistently utilizes vertical integration, rapid innovation, and the development of disruptive technologies. His strategic reasoning—encompassing risk-taking with ambitious deadlines, direct engagement with consumers, and constant technologic advancements—showcases the effectiveness of daring, integrated strategies in transforming entire industries.

Louis V. Gerstner Jr., *Who Says Elephants Can't Dance?* Gerstner's compelling description of IBM's remarkable turnaround offers essential insights into corporate reinvention, clear strategy, and adaptive leadership. His method involved shifting IBM's focus from hardware supremacy to comprehensive services, restructuring the corporate culture, and synchronizing strategic execution via decisive organizationa changes. His narrative highlights the importance of realistic strategy, swift executi

and integrated cultural and strategic changes during crises.

Bryce G. Hoffman, *American Icon: Alan Mulally and the Fight to Save Ford Motor Company.* A detailed examination of Mulally's disciplined and structured approach transforming Ford during a time of crisis. Mulally emphasized strategic simplicity through the "One Ford" plan, maintained ruthless transparency, concentrated intensely on execution, and fostered cultural accountability. This illustrates the effectiveness of coherent, well-communicated strategies paired with disciplined operational execution. Mulally's strategic methodology shows how clarity, alignmei and consistency can steer a company through significant disruption and challenges

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Justin Owings Justin's Substack May 7, 2025

Turns out I have a _lot_ of reading to do on strategy. For anyone who wants it, here's a little spreadsheet with all the above data + an Amazon search link (you'll have to pick which version yo for many of these books). https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1aIfqCfDadSfzraKnJQ_jzYTb0jc5CHX3lz2dyEMAOWU/edit?usp=sharing

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Joachim Sammer Joachim Sammer May 6, 2025

For business strategy: + Rumelt's 'The Crux' as it matures his approach and Martin's Playing to W (while older and flawed, still a valuable read).

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